

Service Provider Promising Practice

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TOPIC:
Working with Staff

Rise: A Data-Driven Approach to Hire and Retain Staff

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BACKGROUND

Rise is a nonprofit service provider supporting people in Minnesota and western Wisconsin. Rise serves about 3,000 people with disabilities each year as well as people experiencing homelessness and people returning to work from incarceration. Rise provides individualized support to people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) in the areas of employment and life enrichment.

In 2020, Rise was serving about 700 people with IDD under the 14c wage certificate in center-based employment and was supporting mobile work crews at local job sites. Rise was also providing supports to individuals who wanted to pursue competitive integrated employment to develop resumes, prepare for interviews, and acquire workplace soft skills. When the COVID-19 public health emergency began in March of 2020, Rise closed several of its locations temporarily due to mandated social distancing restrictions. At that time, Rise had to lay off much of its center-based staff and create remote service options.

Rise was funded by the state to maintain the same level of staffing and supports for people in competitive integrated employment that had been in place prior to COVID-19. Administrators designed hiring and onboarding procedures to be conducted remotely. Employment consultants supporting people in the community in person continued to do so when they could or through phone calls and platforms like Teams and Zoom. Besides continuing to

help people find and maintain work, the employment consultants often supported people to fill out unemployment forms and simply stay connected to people they knew. Program administrators at Rise also created ways to offer center-based vocational and life enrichment classes online, with the long-term goal that once the COVID-19 restrictions were lifted, they would transform their employment services away from subminimum wage employment.

Rise's administrators knew they needed to make changes to their business and staffing models to address immediate and longer-term organizational goals. As part of this effort, they examined and rebuilt many operations related to staffing.

IMPLEMENTATION

Improving the hiring process.

The human resources team rewrote job postings at an accessible reading level, listing all the things direct support professionals get to do, as opposed to what they have to do. They also rewrote their website's content to emphasize the positive impact that Rise staff can have on other people's lives as well as their own. Additionally, Rise's human resources team learned that job applicants are statistically much more likely to respond to texts from prospective employers than open emails from them, so they implemented software that allows texting between Rise's hiring manager and job candidates.

Improving the onboarding experience.

Staff who had been hired in the past



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three years provided feedback about the remote onboarding experience to program administrators. Staff felt like the remote onboarding experience was incomplete. Administrators responded to this feedback by bringing the onboarding process back in person when it was safe to do so. Newer staff have responded much better to this process.

Supporting career growth.

As part of the onboarding process, Rise managers take a person-centered approach toward newer staff, including learning about how they would like to be supported to grow on the job. Rise also offers a clear career path for direct support professionals from entry-level to manager. Most of Rise's employment listings are for entry-level positions because Rise fills higher-level positions internally.

Billable hours.

As a nonprofit service provider, Rise relies on donations and Medicaid rate adjustments to be able to increase their staff's wages. To retain employees through higher pay, administrators researched the minimum salary for a full-time employment consultant and looked at the services an employment consultant provides in terms of billable hours. Rise developed internal incentives for employment consultants to hit a target number of billable hours per day to receive bonus pay. Rise taught employment consultants to keep thorough records of their work time and activities through software to receive the bonus pay. Rise also pays bonuses to staff who reach hiring milestones, such as having worked there for six months and for one year. This record-keeping also became very helpful for Rise's own organizational-level data-tracking efforts.

Employee recognition and community.

Rise has a recognition committee of staff who look for ways to recognize employment

consultants for specific accomplishments and recognize the entire team during the Direct Support Professionals' appreciation week in May. The culture at Rise also encourages staff to publicly recognize each other's accomplishments, and managers are also empowered to offer each other encouragement and feedback to improve their work.

Employee engagement. Every two years, Rise has a third party company administer an employee survey and analyze the results. Administrators say that using survey results to pinpoint and address problems or create new programs leads to more organizational transparency. Employees say it gives them a sense that administrators are listening to and responding to their comments and concerns.

IMPACT

Over the last few years, Rise has eliminated its center-based employment services, and as of April 2024, Rise provides all their employment services in the community. Some direct support professionals stayed on at Rise through this transformation in employment services and staff responsibilities. However, recruiting and retaining direct support professionals, including employment consultants, persists as Rise's number one challenge. Rise has calculated that they need to hire 70 more people to be at full staff capacity to support people on their waitlist.

Despite the recruitment challenges, Rise's efforts to retain staff are having a positive impact on the organization and on outcomes for the people being served. Rise has access to a bigger talent pool from which to recruit since it offers staff a hybrid work schedule and so many services are provided in the community. Rise's support for career advancement has led to a strong team of experienced program leaders who are good at providing supports and services and can teach newer employees.

SUGGESTIONS FOR REPLICATION

- » **Revise hiring strategies.** Revising job postings, organizational websites, and communication strategies allowed Rise to reach a different pool of potential job applicants. Although it is difficult for service providers to compete with other employers on wages, potential employment consultants respond well to the opportunity to do meaningful, valued work.
- » **Collect and use data.** Managers at Rise adjusted their hiring practices based on their data about the most effective ways to identify and hire job candidates. They also tracked employees' time and activities to work out pay raises.
- » **Support career advancement.** Opportunities for employment consultants to develop professionally and move to higher-paying positions are good for retaining people who love this field. Rise also pays bonuses to staff who reach hiring milestones, such as having worked there for six months, one year, and beyond.

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